their houses more for the benefit of the onlookers from outside rather than the advantage of those living inside.' But for all the fine mansions, the crowded bazaars and the ships lurching on the ocean, Surat, and Gujarat itself, possessed a mysterious and enigmatic side that would even impact the court of the Padshah.

The sixteenth century was a time of fizzing fervour in the Islamic world. A belief began to gain currency that the Prophet would return once the old millennium was past, as the Mahdi.* The origins of Mahdavi belief could be traced to Sayyid Muhammad Jaunpuri, a charismatic Chishti Sufi of extreme piety who came to Ahmedabad in 1497 to preach the heretical and incandescent message that he was the Mahdi. 'Proclaim the manifestation of your Mahdiship,' he claimed to have heard, 'and do not fear the people'. Shaikh Jaunpuri died in 1505 but his followers gathered in Gujarat and preached the rejection of formalism in Islam and instead founded communes called dairahs where they spread a message of devotion, renunciation, and meditation to achieve a perfect and direct vision of God. Implicit in the Mahdavi message, however, was a much more dangerous idea. Charged with a fin-de-siecle malaise and an intimation of a forsaken world, the Mahdavis were driven by a divine mission to proselytize, to take up jihad, if necessary, and to give a clear direction to the religious and political elite at a time of impending chaos. This inevitably brought them into confrontation with the orthodox ulema but in Gujarat they were remarkably successful, for a time, in converting the Afghan clans.

The Mahdavi who was to have the most direct impact upon the Padshah, first through Aziz Koka's court at Ahmedabad, then in Sikri, was Shaikh Mustafa Gujarati. Shaikh Mustafa was born in 1525 and gained notoriety from a young age. Combining the usual Mahdavi charisma with a formidable intellect, he founded his own dairah near Patan and married into the family of an important Afghan jagirdar. One of the persons who carried on a correspondence with Shaikh Mustafa on matters of religion was Shaikh Mubarak, Abu'l Fazl's father. But Shaikh Mustafa's radiating popularity, combined with his influential Afghan in-laws, made him dangerous to the Mughals. During Akbar's conquest of Gujarat, encouraged by the sadr, Abd un-Nabi, Mustafa's dairah was plundered and eight members of his family were executed and his women and children imprisoned. Mustafa was captured and brought in chains to the court of Mirza Aziz Koka at Ahmedabad where he was tortured and questioned.